



Tippling to DEATH

In the only major state where prohibition is still in force, another hooch tragedy claims 150 lives, triggering a fresh debate whether the policy should be scrapped

| By Uday Mahurkar |

Since its formation in 1960, prohibition has been in enforcement in Gujarat but to say that the state is the "Land of the Dry" would be, well, spurious. At weddings, social gatherings and corporate dos, booze flows while the police look the other way. Even those unfortunate enough to be caught get away lightly—a fine of Rs 25 or alternately sweeping floors at a public place in atonement for the sin. Little wonder that in the only

major state in the country where prohibition is still in place, its observance is an exception rather than the rule. Denied the opportunity to buy liquor legally from authorised shops, Gujaratis bank on the bootlegger where the booze is cheap, but often spurious and deadly. Last week, tragedy struck in Ahmedabad where over 150 people died due to hooch consumption. The tragedy has triggered a fresh debate whether prohibition is still advisable in Gujarat. Vijay Mallya, who owns India's largest chain of distilleries, must have had his

eyes on the vast Gujarat market, when he donned moral robes and asked Chief Minister Narendra Modi to scrap prohibition, saying the latest deaths exposed the ugly and illicit relationship between the Gujarat Police and bootleggers.

The tragedy gave fresh ammunition to the Opposition Gujarat Congress. It tried to take full advantage of the tragedy by targeting Modi and his Home Minister Amit Shah and demanding that they resign. The deaths resonated in Parliament also where ruling party MPs targeted Modi,